

Class in Residence



Class in Residence: The big idea

The idea of Class in Residence was that a class of children from a local school would relocate their learning for a week, from the classroom to the Museum. The idea was inspired by the My Primary School is at the Museum project that explored the outcomes of extended cultural contact between schools and museums over a number of weeks. We were keen to see if some of the same outcomes could be achieved in a single week. Our experience of being part of the Museums and Schools programme was that multiple visits by the same students and teacher resulted in positive outcomes for children but also positive impacts on classroom practice and curriculum planning. Class in Residence also therefore sought to explore the impact of working closely with the teacher to plan the detail of the week's curriculum learning.

Museum name and location:

Captain Cook Birthplace Museum and Stewart Park, Marton, Middlesbrough

School name and location:

Lingfield Primary, Marton, Middlesbrough

Year group and number of children

Year 1: 31 children

Partners

Education officers from the Museum, the Park and partner Tees Valley museums, the Deputy Head at Lingfield who teaches Year 1

Topic/theme

Dinosaur Planet

Curriculum areas covered

Maths, English, History, Geography, Art and Design, Computing, PHSE

What were the outcomes for the students?

Key outcomes for children included:

- Knowledge gain around dinosaurs, palaeontology, geology, archaeology and geography
- Skills gain in coding, historical enquiry, creative and critical thinking, independent learning, and speaking and listening
- Vocabulary gain, especially in mathematical positional language
- Writing development in spelling, handwriting and motivation to write
- Behavioural improvements: motivation to attend and learn was high and there were no behavioural incidents distracting from learning
- Relationship gains: the shared experience of the week contributed positively to teacher-student and parent-school relationships
- Cultural capital gains: children felt a sense of ownership over the Museum and Park



"Throughout the week there was an emphasis on speaking and listening which has enabled the children to talk about their learning more clearly and has also helped them formulate their ideas in writing." **Teacher**

One girl struggles to concentrate when writing in the classroom but on this task she wrote long, extended sentences: 'The dinosaur is between the rock and the flower and he is very big and likes eating grass.' **Observer**

"He has enjoyed the experience. He seems more confident to discuss what he did during the day and who he did it with. It seems to have improved his confidence in front of people." **Parent**

"He always has to be prompted to talk about the things he does at school but he was keen to tell us what he did each day and woke up each morning talking about going to 'school' and what they were going to do." **Parent**

"He was very excited during the week, and enthusiastic to learn. He was worried he'd miss the school bus on a morning so actually got dressed no problem." **Parent**

"She told her Grandma and Grandad: It's so much fun learning about fossils." **Parent**

How was the week planned?

The week was planned in close collaboration between the teacher at Lingfield Primary and the education officer at the Museum, with support from the Park education officer, the partnership Learning Advisor and a researcher from UCL who was part of the My Primary School is at the Museum project. The teacher retained responsibility for developing and assessing the children's learning in line with the curriculum for the week. The education officer supported planning, organised resources and set up the learning space each day, with help from colleagues.



What activities were included in the week and how were they delivered?

Activities were team taught by the teacher and education officer, supported by a teaching assistant and parents. During the week children:

- handled fossils and bones
- dressed up and role played being palaeontologists
- went on a dinosaur hunt in the Park
- worked with an artist to design and make a dinosaur out of felt
- used Google Expeditions to "see" dinosaurs
- wrote "fact files" on dinosaurs
- explored the galleries at the Museum, and heard about Captain Cook
- learned about the continents of the world
- heard about Lewis Hunton, a local Victorian geologist

Throughout the week teaching about phonics and mathematical positional vocabulary was threaded through games, activities and conversations.

Although the Museum education space was the main base for activities, each day children also used different spaces within the Museum and/or Park. On the final afternoon, family adults came to the Museum to see everything the children had been doing.

How did the teacher benefit?

Whilst the week was intensive and exhausting, the teacher felt it had been hugely worthwhile. She felt that planning and delivering in a new learning environment had challenged her classroom practice and team planning and teaching had been a very positive experience.

"As a class teacher, it was great professional development to work with the education officer from the museum to plan, deliver and evaluate lessons. It made me reflect on my practice and how I can use more hands-on resources in school."

How did the school benefit?

In addition to good outcomes for both the children and the teaching staff, there were some unexpected outcomes for the school. The most significant of these was around engaging parents in children's learning. Almost all families were able to come to the celebration of the week that took place on the final Friday afternoon. Children briefly presented their work and then spent over an hour showing parents what they had been doing and explaining what they had learned. Family adults were so engaged with this that the school decided to do the same for other year groups in school. Within a month, two other year groups had had sharing afternoons where students could talk to their grown-ups about their learning.

How did the Museum benefit?

The education officer was clear that the week's adventure had been just as valuable for her and the Museum as it had been for the school. She reported that she had gained great insight into best practice in classroom teaching and the daily demands on teachers, plus she had identified approaches and activities that would be useful in her own programme. The week has provided a wonderful shared experience on which the Museum can begin to build an on-going relationship with the school.

What challenges were there and how were they overcome?

Although the week was a clear success, there were many practical and logistical challenges. The evaluation of the original My Primary School project had highlighted some that were able to be mitigated in planning Class in Residence, such as dedicated space for lunch and playtimes and extra museum staff to help clear away and set up. Planning in detail together also addressed potential challenges around smooth delivery of learning and covering enough of the curriculum to justify the time out of school.

During the week, the most significant issues were:

- transport: the bus could not come to the Museum door, so children walked from the car park. This was a significant walk for young legs, sometimes in poor weather
- the toilets: their location meant that an adult had to supervise children at all times, which took away from learning time
- access to water: not having constant access to water meant that drinks had to be planned in
- lunch space: using the classroom as a lunch space had cleaning implications
- teacher breaks: the teacher supervised children at all times so got no break herself

What are the ingredients for success?

Reflecting on their experience, the partners identified some of the key reasons the week was a success:

- team planning and teaching
- the level of experience of the teacher
- support from the TA, parents and Park and Museum staff
- having a topic that could be supported through collections
- planning a creative and playful week of learning
- involving parents and carers on the last afternoon

"When we came back on Friday both my teaching assistant and I said 'Gosh, we're exhausted. Wasn't it so worthwhile? It was really really worthwhile.'"

